

Reading

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Capitals That Might Surprise You

Before you read

- Look at the title. Which capital cities do you already know? Name three.
- Guess: is the biggest city in a country always its capital?

When people think of a capital city, they often imagine the biggest, busiest city in the country. But that isn't always true. In some countries, the capital is a smaller, quieter administrative city, built specially to be the seat of government.

Brazil is a good example. Rio de Janeiro used to be the capital, but in 1960 the government had already decided to relocate the capital to a new city called Brasília. City planners had designed Brasília from nothing, in the shape of an aeroplane, in the middle of the country. Today, government buildings, embassies and diplomats fill the city, while Rio remains the more famous tourist destination.

Another surprising example is Switzerland. Many people guess that Zürich, the biggest and richest city, is the capital. In fact, Bern, a much smaller city with a lower population, holds that role. Bern's old town, with its narrow streets and medieval towers, is now a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

Turkey has a similar story. Istanbul is the largest city and the main cultural and economic centre, but Ankara has been the official capital since 1923, when the young republic had chosen it as a more central administrative city.

So, before you travel, it's worth checking: is the capital the city everyone talks about, or is it a quieter place with a very different kind of importance?

1. What is the text mainly about?

- a. Why capital cities are always the biggest city
- b. Capital cities that are not the biggest or most famous city in their country
- c. How to become a diplomat

2. Why did Brazil relocate its capital to Brasília?

- a. Rio de Janeiro was destroyed
- b. The government wanted a new, planned administrative city
- c. Brasília is the biggest city

3. What shape was Brasília designed in?

- a. A circle
- b. An aeroplane
- c. A star

4. In paragraph 3, what is true about Bern?

- a. It is Switzerland's biggest city
- b. It is smaller than Zürich but is the capital
- c. It has no government buildings

5. Istanbul has been the official capital of Turkey since 1923. — True / False

6. Why does the writer suggest checking before you travel?

- a. Because tickets are expensive
- b. Because the capital isn't always the city everyone knows about
- c. Because capitals change every year

After you read

- Which country's capital surprised you most? Write two sentences.
- Choose a capital city you would like to visit and give one reason why.

The Landmark and the Story Behind It

Before you read

- Look at the title. Which famous landmark do you think this text is about?
- Guess: was this landmark originally built for the reason people visit it today?

Millions of tourists visit the Eiffel Tower every year, but most don't know it was almost destroyed. In 1889, the tower had been built as a temporary entrance for the World's Fair in Paris. Many people at the time thought it was ugly, and the plan was to take it down after twenty years.

By the time the twenty years had passed, engineers had already found a new use for the tower: radio transmission. Because it was so tall, it was perfect for sending radio signals across the city. This breathtaking piece of engineering had earned itself a permanent place in Paris.

Today, the tower attracts around seven million visitors a year, making it one of the most-visited paid landmarks in the world. Tourists climb it, take photographs from below, and watch it sparkle with lights every evening.

This story shows something interesting about landmarks: sometimes they aren't built to become symbols. Their history, use, and the culture around them can change how people see a place over time.

So next time you take a photo next to a famous monument, it might be worth asking: what was this place originally built for, and how did it become so important?

1. What is the text mainly about?

- a. How to build a tower
- b. The surprising history behind a famous landmark
- c. The cost of visiting Paris

2. Why was the Eiffel Tower originally built?

- a. As a permanent monument
- b. As a temporary entrance for the World's Fair
- c. As a radio station

3. What saved the tower from being destroyed?

- a. Tourists loved it
- b. It was useful for radio transmission
- c. It was too expensive to remove

4. About how many visitors does the tower attract each year?

- a. Around seven thousand
- b. Around seven hundred thousand
- c. Around seven million

5. The Eiffel Tower was always planned as a permanent monument. — True / False

6. What point does the writer make at the end of the text?

- a. Landmarks never change their purpose
- b. A landmark's history and culture can change how people see it over time
- c. All landmarks are built for tourists

After you read

- Do you know the story behind a landmark in your own city or country? Write two sentences.
- Which capital city or landmark would you include in a project about your ideal world tour? Give one reason.